EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

# Did Yonah Really Run Away?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:5-6

**Sefer:** Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 3 (Commandment and Prohibition), Chapters 5-6 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 30 September 2024, on Zoom (the last shiur before Rosh Hashanah)

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

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## Recap: Where We Are in Essay 3

The third essay is about **the mitzvot**. So far:

| Chapter | What Saadia told us |
|---|---|
| **Introduction** | Hashem created the world **to bestow goodness**; the mitzvot and staying away from the *aveirot* are the means to the best life |
| **1-2** | Two categories: the **rational mitzvot** (*sichliyot*), self-understood, and the **revelatory mitzvot** (*shim'iyot*), which Hashem has to tell us. He gave reasons for some of both |
| **3** | Even the rational mitzvot came through prophets, mainly because **we need an exact framework**. We know adultery is wrong, but what makes a woman married? The Nevi'im and the Torah gave the rational mitzvot their structure |
| **4** | A prophet is **verified through miracles**, "which was surprising, but that was his approach." The **Rambam** strongly disagreed: the sign is **foretelling the future** and having it come true. Saadia also stressed that **a prophet is a regular human being**, unlike the **Kuzari**, for whom he is almost a kind of angel |

Tonight: **Chapter 5**, in three parts (how the prophet himself knows, the Egyptian magicians, and Yonah, "topical as well," just before the Yamim Noraim), and **Chapter 6**, in two parts (the structure of the Torah, and why we can trust the tradition).

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## Part 1: How Does the Prophet Himself Know?

Last week was about how **we, the public**, know a prophet is genuine. But **how does the prophet know** that what he is experiencing is a real prophecy?

The Rabbi admitted he was surprised by the question, since Saadia already told us in Essay 2 about the ***kavod nivra***, the created glory the prophet sees. Perhaps Saadia is asking something sharper: how does the prophet know **this isn't a hallucination**, or that it doesn't come **from the wrong side**?

## Saadia: a visible sign

When the prophecy begins, the prophet sees **a clear sign**, and it departs when the prophecy ends:

- **A pillar of cloud**, or
- **A pillar of fire**, or
- **An extraordinary, shining light**, not ordinary light.

When he sees it he knows for certain that he is now prophesying. **Sometimes the public sees it too**, which is then a further verification, though that does not always happen.

## The proof from Ki Tisa

When Moshe went to the Tent, the people would look out at a clear sky. As the prophecy began, **a pillar of cloud descended**, stood at the entrance of the Tent, and Hashem spoke with Moshe. The cloud stayed for as long as the prophecy lasted.

> When Moshe entered the Tent, the **והיה כבא משה האהלה ירד עמוד הענן ועמד פתח האהל ודבר עם משה** pillar of cloud would descend and stand at the entrance of the Tent, and He would speak with Moshe. (Shemot 33:9)

The Rabbi noted it is peculiar that Saadia quotes the verse before this one and not this main verse. When Moshe came back to tell them the prophecy, the people could say: this is all true, we saw the clear sky, we saw the cloud come down on you, and it stayed exactly as long as you were prophesying.

## Not only Moshe

Moshe was a different kind of prophet, and with the other prophets we do not find a clear sign. But Tehillim shows it applied to all of them:

> Moshe and Aharon among His priests, and **משה ואהרן בכהניו ושמואל בקראי שמו... בעמוד ענן ידבר אליהם** Shmuel among those who call His name... **in a pillar of cloud He would speak to them.** (Tehillim 99:6-7)

The Gemara famously **equates Shmuel with Moshe and Aharon**: Shmuel is the quintessential prophet after Moshe, "Moshe in his generation, Shmuel in his generation." Since we find the cloud with both, in two different generations, all the prophets must have had some such sign.

## The Ramchal: the prophet feels it in his body

The Rabbi set against this the approach of the **Ramchal in Derech Hashem**, which some of the class had learned with him a few years earlier. "In a sense you could say that this is what the *kavod nivra* is really about."

- **Prophecy is not essentially a message.** We find **thousands of prophets** in our history, and we have messages from only a handful: Yechezkel, Yirmiyahu, Yehoshua and the other main prophets whose books we have.
- **The essence of prophecy** is **the deep connection with Hashem while we are still in our bodies**. It is rewarding in itself: understanding, developing one's intellect, knowing Hashem.
- **So the body feels it.** The whole body trembles. All the prophets apart from Moshe would **crumble and fall to the floor** when prophecy began, as we see with Eli and the start of Shmuel's prophecy. Fear would envelop them and they would know they were experiencing the divine.

| | How the prophet knows |
|---|---|
| **Saadia** | **An external sign**: a cloud, fire or light |
| **The Ramchal** | **An internal experience**: a clear feeling in the body |

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## Part 2: Could the Egyptian Magicians Do Miracles?

If miracles verify a prophet, Saadia faces an obvious question. The Torah tells us the **Egyptian sorcerers** also turned water into blood and brought frogs out of the Nile. "How can I say that miracles are a proof of prophecy, if the Egyptians can do the same?"

### Ten against three

- **Moshe performed ten wonders: the staff turned into a snake**, and **the first nine plagues**, in which Moshe was involved, sometimes with Aharon, but leading them. The tenth plague does not count, since Moshe did nothing for it; it simply happened at midnight.
- **The magicians matched only three:** the staff into a snake, the blood and the frogs. (The Rabbi corrected himself in the shiur: the Torah is clear that they **could not** do the lice.)

### "Belateihem": in secret

Each time, the Torah says the magicians did the same **בלטיהם** (*belateihem*). Saadia says this word **always means secretly, deceptively**. He brings it from the root לט, covering or wrapping:

**הנה היא לוטה בשמלה אחרי האפוד**: the sword of Golyat, "wrapped in a cloth behind the ephod."

**הלוט הלוט על כל העמים**: "the covering that covers all the nations."

**וילט פניו באדרתו**: he **wrapped his face in his cloak**.

- Speaking to David **בלט**, in secret.

So the Torah is not comparing them to Moshe but **contrasting** them. "Reuven said things which make sense, whereas Shimon said corrupt things." Moshe did it **as Hashem commanded**; the Egyptians did it **in their secret, deceptive way**. "They were playing with your eyes."

### How they did it

Saadia says he does not need to demonstrate it at length, but:

- **The blood:** they did it **in small places**, perhaps putting in some potion beforehand to turn the water red.
- **The frogs:** again **in small areas**, perhaps putting something in the water to make the frogs come out.
- **Moshe**, by contrast, changed **all** the water and brought frogs out of **every part of the Nile**, a vast stretch said to run from the south of Egypt to Alexandria. That cannot be done by deception. "That's clearly the work of Hashem."
- **The staff into a snake** Saadia does not explain, "but you have to say, like people do magic tricks nowadays: a quick flash of the hands, a quick exchange, and I've changed my staff into a snake."

### Ibn Ezra and Rashi on the word

Not all the Rishonim read the word this way.

| Commentator | Root of the word | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| **Saadia** | **לט**, covering | **Secretly**, deceptively |
| **Ibn Ezra** | **להט**, as in **להט החרב המתהפכת**, the flaming sword at the gate of Eden | **Shining**, a quick flash like a spark. The same idea as Saadia, **sleight of eye** (*achizat einayim*), from a different root |
| **Rashi** (and **Onkelos**) | **Similar to** *lahat hacherev*, but not the same word | **with their incantations**. The sword at Eden **בלחשיהם**, seemed to turn by itself, as if worked by an incantation |

"It's not an essential point, but if you understand what I'm saying, I think it's a very interesting one." Rashi clearly knew of a link between this word and the turning sword, but did not understand the link as the Ibn Ezra did, "which is probably the correct one." The consequence: for Rashi the magicians really did something, so **Rashi would still have Saadia's question**. For Saadia and the Ibn Ezra, the question is answered. **They never really did it.**

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## Part 3: Did Yonah Really Run Away?

"Topical. And Saadia comes up with a very original answer."

The question: prophecy is given to **reliable, verified** people. So how can Tanach tell of a prophet who **did not carry out his prophecy**? At the centre of Yom Kippur we read the story of **Yonah**, sent to Nineveh, who runs away to Tarshish. Why would Hashem choose someone who would not do what he was told?

### Saadia: he did go

Nowhere in the four chapters of the book of Yonah **does it say that Yonah did not do what he was told.**

It does not say that he went, but Saadia insists we must assume he did, **because Hashem would never choose someone who would refuse**. He brings cases where Hashem tells Moshe to speak to the people and the Torah never says Moshe went and spoke. We simply assume he did. So too with Yonah.

### Then why did he flee?

Because of **a change and addition** in Hashem's message. The sequence, as the Rabbi laid it out:

1. **The first mission** was only **a warning** to Nineveh. Yonah went, delivered it, and did his job.
2. Yonah feared he would be **sent a second time**, now with **a clear reprimand and its consequences**.
3. He knew that this time **the people would do teshuvah**, the decree would be annulled, **and they would think he was a liar**.
4. So **before he could be sent again**, he fled to a place where there is **no prophecy**.
5. Hashem brought him back to the place of prophecy, so that he would prophesy the second time. He told them the consequences, they did teshuvah, and the decree was annulled.

This explains the end of the book, where Yonah says: I knew that You are **merciful**, and that is why I fled. "Fascinating, says Saadia. The story of Yonah, you've misunderstood it all these years." He was not given a prophecy and then escaped. **He did exactly what he was told**, and ran only before the second mission. "I wonder if anyone's ever read the story like this."

### The Kuzari and the Ibn Ezra

- **The Kuzari** teaches that prophecy is only **in the Land of Israel**, or about it, and that Yonah fled **the place of prophecy** and Hashem returned him. Perhaps the Kuzari means the same as Saadia, that he fled to avoid being prophesied to a second time. "Maybe the Kuzari means that, maybe not."
- **The Ibn Ezra**, in his introduction to the book of Yonah, brings Saadia's explanation and **rejects it**, giving a different interpretation.

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## Part 4: Chapter 6, The Structure of the Torah

The Torah is not only commands and prohibitions. It is full of **stories**. What are they for?

### Three components

Saadia says the Torah contains:

1. **Commands and prohibitions.**
2. **Consequences**, "the fruits of your actions": what happens if you do and if you don't.
3. **Historical narratives**: accounts of people who did good and were rewarded and who did bad and were punished, through which **we improve our service and our character**.

This, he says, is how **all wise books of all nations** are written, different as they are. A proper framework needs all three.

### The parable of the doctor

A man has a fever, and the doctor sees he has too much blood.

| What the doctor says | Saadia's verdict |
|---|---|
| "Don't eat meat or drink wine." | Good, but **incomplete** |
| "...so that your fever doesn't worsen and kill you." | **Much better**: with the consequence, he is more likely to listen. Still not complete |
| "...just as So-and-so had this fever, ate meat and drank wine, and died." | **Complete**: command, consequence and example |

### The same parable in Rashi

The Rabbi pointed out that this is **almost identical to a Midrash**, quoted by Rashi on the verse read on Yom Kippur: Hashem spoke to Moshe **after the death of Aharon's two sons**, and told him to tell Aharon not to enter the Holy of Holies at any time.

Rashi (Vayikra 16:1): a parable of a sick man visited by a doctor who tells him, **don't eat cold food and don't lie in a damp place**. Another doctor comes and says, don't eat cold food and don't lie in a damp place, **so that you don't die the way So-and-so died**. The second one got through to him.

"Whether Saadia knew of this or not, it's interesting. The exact example is different but it's the same idea." The verse itself has all three parts: **the command** (do not enter), **the consequence** (lest you die), and **the example** (the two sons of Aharon who entered and died).

### A note for Essay 4

"We have to bear this in mind." If the narratives show good deeds rewarded and bad deeds punished, that **seems to imply reward and punishment in this world**. The Rabbi flagged it to return to when Saadia discusses reward and punishment in the next essay.

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## Part 5: How Do We Know the Torah Is True?

"A very famous part of Emunot VeDeot, which is commonly quoted. Let's see it in its full context." Saadia touched on it in his Introduction; here he goes into it.

### Life depends on reports

Hashem knew we would need the Torah **handed down** so that later generations could know it is true as the first generation did. So He gave us the ability to receive from others, and **a place in our heart to believe what we hear**. Without relying on reports:

- **Commerce:** someone tells you that if you do this in business you will do well. "How do I know? I never saw it."
- **Danger:** someone tells you not to go down that path at night, or that there are many accidents on this road.
- **Instructions:** you would only do what you were told while the person stood in front of you. Saadia takes it to an extreme: you would **even come to doubt your own memory**.
- **Inheritance and family:** you would not know that this belonged to your father or grandfather. "How do we know this is my mother? Because you're told as a child, this is your mother, this is your father."

Without reports **we would have no hope and no fear**. Believing only what you can sense is the approach of **the skeptics** from Essay 1. The Rabbi added that we know nowadays that data and information are always manipulated to some degree, "but we do rely on reports in the broad sense."

### The verse: seeing and hearing are equal

> Cross to the isles of the Kittim **and see**; send to Kedar **כי עברו איי כתיים וראו, וקדר שלחו והתבוננו מאד and pay close attention**. (Yirmiyahu 2:10)

Saadia sees here that the Torah **equates seeing with hearing a report**. A verified report is almost like sensing something yourself. But why add **והתבוננו מאד**, "pay very close attention"?

### Two ways a report goes wrong

1. **An error of reasoning.** The person wants to tell the truth but has got it wrong.
2. **Wilful deception.** He is lying to you.

Both happen **with one person**. But:

- **Many people together will not all make the same mistake.**
- If many people **conspire to fabricate** a story, **it can never stay hidden**. Wherever the report travels, **the story of how it came about travels with it**.

The Torah was received by **vast numbers**, so it is safe from both.

### The Introduction filled this out

The Rabbi reminded the class that Saadia was more detailed in **Chapter 6 of the Introduction**, and added a point he "fails to mention here, which I don't really understand, because this is crucial":

- **"You are My witnesses."** The Torah tells the people **you saw it**: the ten plagues, the splitting of the sea, the revelation at Sinai. You cannot tell people they saw something they did not see.
- **The manna is the greatest of the miracles**, because **a continuous miracle is greater than a one-off**. How could a couple of million people live forty years in the desert without food? "If people knew how to do this, the philosophers would have provided for their students," and in those days the philosophers and academics were poor.
- If parents told their children "we ate manna for forty years" and it never happened, the children would answer: **this is your field, we saw you eating its fruit.**

"I can be the most charismatic person, and perhaps I can make up a whole story about something that happened in a faraway land and convince you. But it's going to be very, very hard to tell you that **yesterday you did X** when you never did X, and convince you that you did it."

"Almost identical to what the Kuzari would say a couple of centuries later."

### From the class

**Chaim** objected: the claim does not hold water. We see leaders in the world today who cheat, and whole peoples are deceived and follow them. The Rabbi answered with the saying, "**You can fool some of the people all the time, you can fool all the people some of the time, but you can't fool all the people all the time.**" Leaders lie about what is happening in some faraway land, and many people believe them. But to stand before thousands and tell them that **they themselves** saw smoke from heaven and ate manna for forty years, and then have them pass it on to their children, is not possible however charismatic you are.

Chaim pressed further: perhaps someone wrote the story much later and told people, "these are your ancestors." The Rabbi said he would go over this point properly the following week.

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## Summary

1. **How the prophet knows:** for Saadia, **an external sign**, a cloud, fire or light, as with Moshe in the Tent and Shmuel ("in a pillar of cloud He would speak to them"). For the **Ramchal**, an inner experience: the body trembles and falls.
2. **The Egyptian magicians** did not really perform miracles. **בלטיהם** means **secretly, deceptively**, in small places and by sleight of hand. The Ibn Ezra agrees on the idea; Rashi reads "with their incantations."
3. **Yonah did go.** He delivered the warning, then fled **before a second mission** with consequences, fearing Nineveh's teshuvah would make him look a liar. The Ibn Ezra rejects this reading.
4. **The structure of the Torah:** commands, consequences and stories, like the doctor's prescription, a parable that appears in Rashi on Acharei Mot. It hints at reward and punishment in this world, a point for Essay 4.
5. **The truth of the Torah:** life runs on reports; a report fails through error or deceit; a tradition held by a whole people, about **what they themselves saw**, can be neither.

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## Coming Up

- **Next week, Monday 7 October:** the anniversary of 7 October, so the shiur will be at the earliest possible time, **5.15**, so everyone can go on to their commemorative services. After that, back to after Mincha and Arvit.
- **Chapter 7:** abrogation, and how we know the Torah cannot be superseded. Chaim's question will be taken up first.

- The Rabbi wished everyone **a Shanah Tovah**.

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